

Grape Variety Aroma Guide

Core Aromas · Cool Climate · Warm Climate

The same grape variety can smell remarkably different depending on where it's grown. Cooler climates preserve acidity and produce more restrained, earthy, mineral-driven wines. Warmer climates push ripeness, producing richer, fruit-forward, sometimes jammy profiles. Use this guide to decode what climate and winemaking decisions are telling you in the glass.

RED & ROSÉ GRAPES			
Grape	Core Aromas	Cool Climate	Warm Climate
Cabernet Sauvignon	Black currant, cedar, cigar box, green bell pepper	Cassis, graphite, tobacco leaf, bell pepper more pronounced (Bordeaux)	Ripe blackberry, chocolate, baked plum, vanilla (Napa)
Syrah / Shiraz	Black pepper, smoked meat, dark olive, violet	Violet, bacon fat, iron/blood, blueberry (Northern Rhône)	Blueberry jam, chocolate, eucalyptus, dark spice (Barossa)
Pinot Noir	Red cherry, raspberry, forest floor, wet earth	Cranberry, rose petal, mushroom, barnyard (Burgundy, Willamette)	Strawberry jam, cola, cinnamon, dried cherry (Central Coast, Marlborough)
Grenache / Garnacha	Red cherry, orange peel, white pepper	Red fruit freshness, lavender, iron (Sardinia, high elevation)	Dried herbs, raspberry jam, leather, licorice (Southern Rhône, Priorat)
Sangiovese	Sour cherry, tomato, dried herbs, leather	Dried rose, earthy/dusty, oregano (Chianti Classico)	Dried fig, tobacco, tar, dark cherry (Brunello di Montalcino)
Nebbiolo	Tar, roses, sour cherry	More floral lift, red fruit at higher altitude (Piedmont)	Dried violets, leather, anise, truffle with age (Barolo/Barbaresco)
Malbec	Violet, dark cherry, plum, chocolate	Inky, plum, tobacco, leather (Cahors, France)	Violet, dark cherry, cocoa, mocha (high-altitude Mendoza)
Tempranillo	Leather, tobacco, dried cherry, tomato leaf	More red fruit, graphite, blackberry (Ribera del Duero)	Vanilla, dill, coconut, dusty earth with American oak (Rioja)
Zinfandel / Primitivo	Blackberry jam, black pepper, baking spice	More rustic, dried plum, licorice, leather (Primitivo, Puglia)	Ripe raspberry, vanilla, smoky, sometimes port-like (California)
Mourvèdre / Monastrell	Blackberry, game/meat, iron	Olive, lavender, animal/barnyard, leather (Bandol)	Inky, dark chocolate, dried black fruit, tobacco (Jumilla)
Merlot	Plum, chocolate, bay leaf	Truffle, mocha, cassis, silky earthiness (Pomerol, Saint-Émilion)	Blueberry, vanilla, cocoa powder, cedar (California, Washington)
Carménère	Dark cherry, green pepper, smoked paprika	More savory, red fruit, bell pepper (cooler coastal Chile)	Chocolate, black olive, coffee, dried herbs (warmer Chilean valleys)
Petit Verdot	Violet (very floral), blackcurrant, dark chocolate	Pencil shaving, graphite, structured tannin	Ink, espresso, leather, very full-bodied (Virginia, Australia, California)

WHITE GRAPES

Grape	Core Aromas	Cool Climate	Warm Climate
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Chardonnay	Apple, lemon, butter (when oaked)	Green apple, chalk/flint, lemon curd (Chablis, Champagne)	Ripe peach, tropical fruit, vanilla, toasted oak (Napa, Australia)
Sauvignon Blanc	Grapefruit, cut grass, white peach	Flinty/mineral, gooseberry, jalapeño (Sancerre, Loire)	Passionfruit, guava, cat pee/thiols (Marlborough NZ)
Riesling	Lime, green apple, petrol (with age)	Slate/mineral, white peach, honey if late harvest (Mosel)	Lemon curd, apricot, marmalade (Clare Valley, Alsace)
Viognier	Peach, apricot, honeysuckle	Floral violet, white peach, ginger, lanolin (Condrieu)	Mango, orange blossom, heavy perfume, oily texture (California)
Grüner Veltliner	White pepper, green herbs, lemon	Crisp grapefruit, radish, fresh herbs (Weinviertel)	White peach, mineral/flinty, celery seed, honeyed with age (Wachau)
Gewurztraminer	Lychee, rose petal, ginger	Turkish delight, exotic spice, mango, sometimes diesel (Alsace)	Even more perfumed, lower acidity, overwhelming floral (warmer regions)
Chenin Blanc	Quince, green apple, lanolin, honey	Beeswax, wet wool, chamomile, ginger (Vouvray, Savennières)	Guava, ripe melon, dried apricot, waxy tropical richness (South Africa)
Pinot Gris / Pinot Grigio	Pear, lemon, almond	Light, crisp, pear, lemon, neutral (Italian Pinot Grigio)	Smoked bacon, honey, baked pear, ginger, white truffle (Alsace)
Albariño / Alvarinho	Peach, lemon zest, saline/ocean spray	White grapefruit, apricot, crushed stone, salty finish (Rías Baixas)	Lighter, citrus-forward, green apple, floral, slight spritz (Vinho Verde)
Assyrtiko	Lemon, lime, volcanic mineral/ash	Green citrus, saline, flint, electric acidity (Santorini)	Rarely grown warm — Santorini's wind keeps it cool despite the heat

Note on Climate

These are generalizations — altitude, proximity to ocean, aspect of the vineyard slope, and vintage variation all play a role. A 'warm climate' grape planted at high altitude (e.g. Malbec in Uco Valley, Mendoza at 1,000m+) can show cool-climate characteristics. Always consider the full picture.